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More than just a 12th man

The **Impact Player** rule has transformed the IPL, but teams may still be overlooking its greatest strategic value. A look at the innovations, opportunities and tactical blind spots that defined the 2026 season.

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The IPL 2026 match between Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Mumbai Indians in Raipur was significant in many ways. RCB has since identified it as the match that gave it momentum on the way to the title, while the defeat meant both MI and LSG were eliminated from playoff contention.

Yet one of the most interesting aspects of the match was something that did not happen at all. MI opted to name leg-spinner Raghu Sharma as its Impact Player, but on a tricky wicket, he did not bowl a single over. It was the second time in the season MI had done so, having previously brought Shardul Thakur into a match against Sunrisers Hyderabad before leaving him unused.

The effect of the Impact Player on the IPL is well-documented. Aided by flat pitches and small grounds, it has kick-started a batting boom in the IPL, with scoring rates ascending rapidly, along with the number of 200+ scores put up and chased. Those outcomes have attracted heavy criticism.

But the more revealing question is not what impact the rule has had on the IPL, but how it has changed the

competition itself. The most instructive place to start is by examining the strategies teams have employed.

Breaking down the strategy

At its simplest, the Impact Player rule affords every team the option to add an extra batter and bowler to its lineup. The identity and profile of the Impact Player is variable, with teams showing little preference for players of specific roles.

Instead, the identity of a team's Impact Player tended to be shaped more by the dynamics of its squad, with players carrying injuries, one-skilled players, or weaker fielders generally preferred.

An illustrative example is Finn Allen. Allen became KKR's de facto